CRISIS BRIEFING (EXPRESS): "The Friday Counterfeit"

To: Operational Task Force (both teams)
Classification: Urgent. Do not distribute outside this room.
Current time: Friday, 2:00 PM
Deadlines: 4:00 PM reporter's comment deadline · 4:15 PM staff lineup · **5:00 PM article publishes and doors open**

You already know how to write a BLUF, triage and pitch. **Nobody will teach you today. You have 15 minutes. Start now.**

1. The Situation

You are the **Operational Task Force** for **Bleu Hen Hospitality Group**, a farm-to-table restaurant group in Delaware: three locations (**Bleu Hen Bistro** in Wilmington, **The Bleu Hen Roost** in Newark, **Bleu Hen Brasserie** in Greenville), about 140 employees, and one promise printed on every menu:

> *"Every bird, every cut, every catch: raised, grown or caught within 75 miles of your table."*

That promise is why guests pay about 40% more here than anywhere comparable. It is the business.

Tonight is **Friday of Valentine's weekend.** All three restaurants are booked solid for **The Lovebird Tasting**, a $185-a-couple dinner whose menu names one farm: **Brandywine Heritage Farms & Fisheries**, your exclusive supplier and a local celebrity (founder **Calvin Teague**).

At 1:41 PM today, investigative reporter **Jo Alvarez** posted a teaser (**Exhibit A**): your "local, sustainable" supplier is a fraud, repackaging cheap out-of-state industrial product, and she has a paper trail. She publishes at **5:00 PM.** She wants your comment on the record by **4:00 PM.** She didn't name you; she didn't have to. Fourteen reservations have canceled in 19 minutes, two TV newsrooms have called, and the Bistro's phones are ringing.

Your walk-ins at all three locations are **stocked with Brandywine product**: chicken, pork, flounder, rockfish, beef. The flounder is portioned. The roulade is rolled.

2. What You Know, and What You Don't

Signals it may be true
- On **Tuesday,** sous chef **Tess Aguilar** found a **second label** under a Brandywine shipping sticker with an out-of-state plant code. She texted a blurry photo to Chef Rafi, who said "Pallets get re-boxed all the time" (**Exhibit C**).
- Brandywine's invoices **dropped 14% in November.** Teague called it "volume pricing."
- The "heritage" pork has lacked its usual marbling for about three weeks.

Signals it may be false or overstated
- You visited the farm twice. The last visit, in September, looked genuine.
- The state agriculture department passed their home farm last spring.
- The teaser names no specifics. Perhaps only some products are affected.
- Teague has years of goodwill, and **60 people** in Sussex County work for him.

You will not be able to confirm any of this by 5:00 PM. You must decide anyway.

3. The Stakes

Sunk inventory in the coolers	**$40,000**
Projected weekend revenue at risk	**$200,000** (1,130 covers, about $177 average check)
Valentine's deposits held	$56,500
Supplier contract	About $1.1M a year; exclusive; **18 months left**
Jobs	About 140 at Bleu Hen, about 60 at Brandywine
Time left	**3 hours**

Every path costs something. **Doing nothing is also a decision.**

4. The People

WHO	ROLE
The Owner	Your boss. Panicked, time-starved, bottom-line focused
Chef Rafi Moreno	Executive Chef, all three kitchens. Fiery, loyal, feels guilty
Tess Aguilar	Sous chef, Riverfront. Raised the alarm Tuesday
Priya Nair	Group GM. Worried about staff and tips
Lena Cho	Marketing. Fielding the press
Hal Brandt	Outside counsel. "Don't say anything you can't prove."

5. Your Three Deliverables (all three, exact limits)

1. **BLUF memo to the Owner:** exactly **3 sentences.** Recommendation first. Include cost and the ask.
2. **3-point operational pivot for Chef Rafi:** exactly **3 points.** Directives, not suggestions. Cover the current food, tonight's service and what Chef does before service.
3. **Front-of-house script for guests at 5:00 PM:** exactly **2 sentences.** Taught at the 4:15 lineup. Must sound human to a nervous couple on Valentine's Day.

6. Rules of Engagement

- **Two teams of 10.** Same facts. You'll pitch separately.
- **15 minutes to prepare.** The facilitator will call time at 5, 2 and 1 minutes left.
- **Deliverables lock at 19:00** on the clock. One copy, on the worksheet. No edits.
- **Pitch: 2 minutes,** then about 6 minutes of questions. Expect to be interrupted within 15 seconds.
- **Pick 1 or 2 spokespeople.** The Owner may question **anyone.**
- **Don't read to the Owner.**
- **New information may arrive.** Be ready.
- The team pitching second **waits outside** during the first pitch. Prepare as if you're first.

7. Suggested Plan for 15 Minutes

MINUTES	DO
0 to 3	Read the brief. Name the decision. **Pick a path.**
3 to 10	Split into three squads (strategy memo, chef pivot, guest script) and draft in parallel
10 to 13	Reconvene. Check the three deliverables tell **one story**
13 to 15	Rehearse the pitch out loud. **Say the cost.**

8. Pitch Structure

Current state → Proposed action (BLUF first) → Immediate cost → The ask.

Exhibits **A** (the teaser) and **C** (text thread) are provided as separate handouts.